

Methodological Journal 1

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1. What do you already believe or know about this topic or issue?

As I stated in my proposal, I want to investigate the factors that influence the success of African American professionals.

I believe that our nation, society, and community are built on the greatness of all people and all ethnic groups. Our society is about embracing diversity and accepting all people with their differences, and this is a proud tradition in America's history. You can find just about any group of people from all parts of the world in America. Just to name a few groups of people in my community, there are people from African, Asian, European, and Latin American backgrounds, among others. Each group of people has a very different culture and way of life. My belief is simple: our society must grow together as a global society, since we all share this planet. This is common knowledge for me on this topic.

What messages have I heard or learned throughout my life?

As an Asian American, I am influenced by Asian culture, and it has shaped me into the person I am today. I know Asian culture and its way of life, because I live it, but I don't know very much about other people's cultures beyond a basic understanding of cultural diversity.

How were these messages reinforced and/or challenged?

I believe that cultural values can have a profound effect on such factors as family, education, social status, and well-being. I have encountered many groups of people from many different places all over the world. Many of the people are my associates at work and school, as well as acquaintances.

As I mentioned in my proposal, I recently encountered an African American student in my advanced .NET programming class, and I am inspired by this individual to study African culture. In my years working in engineering or in school, I haven't seen many successful African American professionals. For this reason, I want to know which factors seem to influence the success of African American professionals.

2. How will these beliefs affect my interaction with the participant?

As I have mentioned above, my Asian heritage and my family values have shaped me into the person I am today. As a poor child growing up in this country, I had to work hard in all aspects of my life to get where I am today. So, I do understand what it takes to succeed in your career. I owe it all to my parents for the values that are central to my beliefs, my life, and my educational direction. For this reason, I believe that success is measured by old-fashioned hard work, dedication, and an unremitting devotion to the things you do. My background is very inline with what I am studying, and I don't see any conflict between my participant and me.

How will they influence how I feel going into the interview?

I believe that I can relate to people who want to advance their lives. Having to rise from the bottom up, I know what it feels like to struggle to succeed.

How will they influence the questions I ask my participant?

I consider myself a successful person both professionally, academically, career-wise, and in life. The questions I ask my participants will be guided by my own personal success story.

3. How have other professional training (and courses) helped me to have a more thoughtful understanding of this topic?

I am a professional engineer. As an engineer, I have to work on a team project with other professionals—other engineers, customers, and partners—to solve problems. I understand the need for people to work together to achieve common objectives. In addition, I have taken several courses on workplace and school ethnic diversity. In fact, companies are required by law to promote diversity in the workplace.

With these understandings, I will treat the interview as a one-on-one meeting with the participant and listen to their life story.

How will those experiences influence how I feel going into the fieldwork project?

Through my experience, I have learned the importance of teamwork and the need for people to work together. I believe that I am very well prepared for the fieldwork project because, as an engineer, I often work on projects that involve many aspects of the project management process, from analysis and design to deployment. The interviewing process for this study is just like a requirement gathering phase, or rather, data collection. The next logical step is the data analysis phase, and following is designing or interpreting the data.

How will they influence the question I ask the participant?

I have planned a three-part interview and prepared the questions in advance. I will base the interview questions on the family's values, beliefs, and religious and cultural background. However, in this kind of environment, I will be a listener and interviewer, and the participant provides the response; I will just observe and record it. The dynamic of an interview depends on the participant's willingness to respond to the interview questions. Nevertheless, I will try to ask the important questions for my study.